

The American Indian Rural Youth Apprenticeship Development Project

The American Indian Rural Youth Apprenticeship Development Project (AI-RYAD) is a development-focused initiative designed to support American Indian Vocational Rehabilitation Services (AIVRS) in creating culturally responsive pre-apprenticeship pathways for American Indian and Alaska Native (AI/AN) youth with disabilities living in rural, Tribal communities.

What are the goals of AI-RYAD?

AI-RYAD aims to:

- Expand access to meaningful pre-apprenticeship opportunities for AI/AN youth with disabilities
- Support culturally grounded workforce development strategies
- Strengthen AIVRS capacity in rural and underserved Tribal communities
- Promote long-term employment and economic opportunities for Tribal youth

Who does AI-RYAD support?

- American Indian Vocational Rehabilitation Services (AIVRS) projects
- Tribal VR staff and leadership
- Tribal education, workforce, and economic development partners
- Community-based organizations supporting AI/AN youth with disabilities

How does AI-RYAD provide support?

AIVRS projects will:

- Receive direct technical assistance in establishing youth-centered pre-apprenticeships
- Gain access to a flexible, culturally responsive Pre-Apprenticeship Implementation Framework that supports the development of pre-apprenticeship pathways for AI/AN youth with disabilities
- Receive an AI-RYAD Toolkit with ready-to-use, customizable resources to support planning and implementation
- Participate in the AI-RYAD Learning Collaborative and Advisory Council for peer learning, shared problem-solving, and connection to Tribal, regional, and national partners

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